



# Q What happens if I get an infectious disease while I'm pregnant?

Treatment options are limited when you are pregnant, so some infections do present risks to your pregnancy. You should contact your doctor if you notice symptoms of serious infections.

## Chicken pox

### » What is it?

Also known as varicella, this viral infection causes fever and itchy red spots on the skin that turn into blisters.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Complications from catching chicken pox are rare, but potentially serious. It can damage a fetus's eyes, brain, skin, limbs, bladder, or bowel. Risks to you include pneumonia, and inflammation in the brain and liver.

### » What can I do?

If you have not had chicken pox before and come into contact with it, or if you develop symptoms, consult your doctor immediately. Antiviral therapy can help prevent any complications, although it can't cure the infection.

## Measles

### » What is it?

Measles causes flulike symptoms, spots in the mouth, and a red-brown rash that lasts for just over a week. Due to vaccination programs, measles is now rare in the US.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Developing measles increases the risk of miscarriage, stillbirth, and premature birth, especially in the first trimester. The infection can also pass to your baby during birth.

### » What can I do?

See your doctor immediately if you come into contact with the virus (it can take up to three weeks to develop) and you are not immune or vaccinated. You can be treated with human normal immunoglobulin (HNIG), which lessens the symptoms and reduces (but doesn't eliminate) the risk to your baby.

## Mumps

### » What is it?

This viral infection causes fever and headache, and swelling of the cheeks and the salivary glands in the neck. Due to vaccination programs, mumps is now rare in the US.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Mumps should not cause any birth defects in your unborn baby, but it can increase the risk of miscarriage through

your fever and illness, especially in your first trimester.

It can also develop into meningitis.

### » What can I do?

If you lack immunity, consult your doctor as soon as you come into contact with anyone with mumps (symptoms may take two to three weeks to develop). Mumps cannot be treated but there are ways to ease the symptoms.

## Rubella

### » What is it?

Also called German measles, the rubella virus causes symptoms of headaches, fever, joint pain, sore throat, swollen glands, and a raised red-pink rash. Due to vaccination programs, rubella is now rare in the US.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

If you contract rubella before you are 18 weeks pregnant, it can cause serious birth defects and miscarriage. The later in pregnancy the disease affects you, the lower the risk. After 18 weeks, the risks to the baby are minimal.

### » What can I do?

If you have not been vaccinated, try to avoid contact with rubella. If you think you could be infected, see your doctor immediately for diagnosis. There is no treatment for rubella, but your doctor will support you and advise options if the baby has congenital rubella syndrome (CRS).

## Cytomegalovirus

### » What is it?

A type of herpes, cytomegalovirus (CMV) is transmitted via saliva, urine, semen, or feces. It can lie dormant (without symptoms) and many people don't realize they have it.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

If you have CMV and it becomes active for the first time

during your pregnancy (a primary infection), it can cause congenital disabilities and neurological problems in your baby. However, only about 1 in 750 babies in the US develops complications due to CMV.

### » What can I do?

There is no cure for CMV, but you can try to prevent primary infection. Children under six are often carriers, so avoid contact with their feces, urine, or saliva (kiss them on the head rather than mouth or cheeks). Many adults don't know they have the virus, so use a condom if you have sex.

## Lyme disease

### » What is it?

This bacterial, tick-borne infection can go undetected for many years. Symptoms include fever, chills, joint or muscle pain, facial paralysis, and a red rash with an outer red ring.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Lyme disease is potentially serious for you if untreated. It increases the risk of premature birth and miscarriage.

### » What can I do?

Your doctor can give you a course of antibiotics—with treatment, the outcome for you and your baby is very good. You can get infected again after treatment, if bitten again, so take precautions to prevent tick bites.

## Hepatitis

### » What is it?

All forms of this blood-borne virus infect the liver. Symptoms can range from vomiting and stomach cramps, to mild, coldlike illness. Some people have no symptoms.

### » What does it mean for my pregnancy?

Hepatitis can cause liver failure in a fetus. All women are offered hepatitis B (HBV) screening as part of prenatal care. Hepatitis C (HCV) is checked if you have risk factors.

### » What can I do?

If you have HBV, your baby can be vaccinated against it at birth—this immunization has a 95 percent success rate. Passing HCV to a baby is more rare, but if your baby is infected he will be referred to a specialist for assessment.

If you are not sure whether you have **immunity** to chicken pox or whether you have been **vaccinated** against measles, mumps, or rubella, your doctor can do a **blood test** to check.